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elections, licitly or not, seems to absolve the winner of any other obligation besides using power for personal ends. The result: over the past 35 years, we have created an imbalanced form of democracy, defined purely as the winning of power, with little demand for accountability. The electorate is given the subordinate and largely impotent pleasure of being able to throw the rascals out, but never the authority of being able to hold them to account for the laws they did or did not pass, the wealth they amassed, the illegalities they committed. And so, the ritual tune at any public discussion of our political life—lamentation over the criminality and corruption of our politicians, and their lack of leadership or personal qualities. The origins of this lament derive from the very expansion and deepening of democracy that Mrs Gandhi enabled, and then, of course, tried to restrain.

The hope of the founders was that elections and politics more generally would bring the best of Indians into leadership positions. Yet over the past 35 years, as elections took hold of the Indian imagination, they brought into office not the best, but the already powerful or the entrepreneurs of power. We are now rightly committed to electoral democracy: and if the results, the venal, self-serving leaders, are a little dismaying, we shall not be rescued from this fact. Great modern democracies are condemned to survive with mediocre leaders. The Nehrus or Roosevelts are the rarity, the Deve Gowdas and Berlusconi the norm. This is why democracies must depend less on individuals and more on ideas and institutions: ideas to orient and chart out where they wish to go and to chart out how to get there, institutions to filter the effects of individual political mediocrities and so to help enable the ideas to be realised.

Like every functioning democracy, we are still wrestling with the problem of how to insert reason, ideas, foresight and vision, into our politics—this murky game of winning and holding power. In our current government, we see this dilemma being played out in dramatic terms. At the Government's head is the ultimate figure of reason and intellect, Manmohan Singh, a man above personal interest or

ideology, a thinker who focuses on the future consequences of current choices. While he takes the long view, he is also surrounded, with the exception of a few colleagues, by the products of our electoral democracy: men who live for numbers, not reason.

This dilemma, endemic to all democracies, will not be resolved in the near term. But we can learn to address it more intelligently than we have done in the years since 1975. Between the authoritarian option—abolish the power of numbers—and the demotic one we currently lean to—expunge the demands of reason—there has to be a better way. The second dimension which also figured in inducing the crisis of 1975, and which like the first is still with us, was the exhaustion of a compelling national story: one that could sustain a common Indian imagination and a belief in why we should, given all our diversities and often conflicting impulses, still hold together as a country.

By 1975, the echoes of nationalism were dying—the JP movement was the last elegiac *shehnai* call of moralised nation-making that brought us to freedom. Mrs Gandhi sought to fill this imaginative silence in two ways. First, she tried to collapse India itself into her person: 'India is Indira and Indira is India', remember? In case that wasn't quite believable, she also played on fear as a way of trying to keep the nation together: fears of anarchy and hoarders, of the foreign hand, of secession and fragmentation, and of Punjab. With her assassination in 1984, she left those behind with fear of the unknown.

So we turned to the familiar. Rajiv Gandhi did initially try to impart some positive content to a national vision. But he too succumbed to a politics of fear, acquiescing to those who refused to recognise Shah Bano's rights as an Indian woman, as he acquiesced to Hindu demands to open the locks of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, as a way of trying to keep us all together. The way was now open to those who would prove to be masters of the politics of fear, and of trying to build a national feeling around it—the ideologues of Hindutva and the leadership of the BJP. Yet this nationalism of fear has proved ever more out of line with India's increasingly youthful

